IMPACT OF COLONIAL ECONOMIC EXPLOITATION ON THE SOCIAL COLLAPSE OF BENGALI SOCIETY

A Sociological Analysis of Bengal

Group- 06

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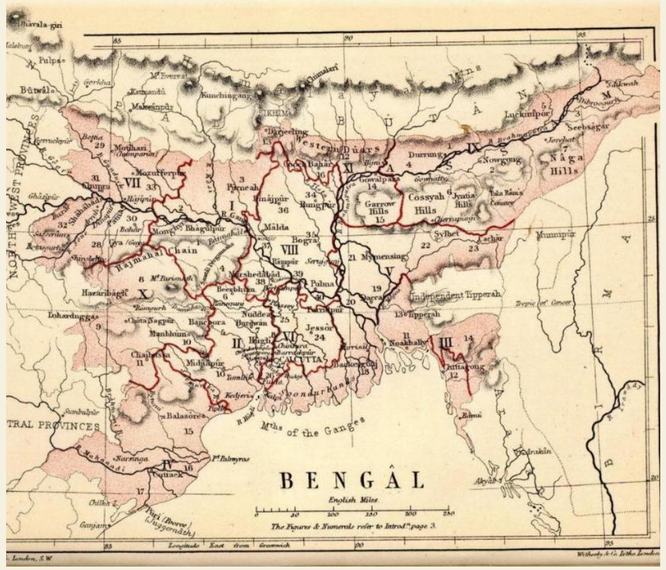
Introduction

- British rule began in Bengal after 1757
- Colonial policies focused on economic extraction
- These policies disrupted agriculture, industry, and society
- This presentation explains how that led to social collapse


BENGAL
English Miles
The Figures & Numerals refer to Introd.n page 3.
Mouths of the Ganges
Naga Hills
Cossyah Hills
Garrow Hills
Jynti Hills
Sylhet
Chittagong
Independent Tipperah
Tipperah
Noakhally
Mymensing
Dacca
Backergunge
Jessore
Nuddea
Burdwan
Hooghly
Midnapore
Balasore
Cuttack
Pooree
Pabna
Rajshahy
Bogra
Rungpore
Dinagipore
Malda
Purneah
Bhagulpore
Monghyr
Tirhoot
Durbhunga
Sarun
Shahabad
Gya
Patna
Chittagong
Arracan
Tavoy
Mergui
Martaban
Tenasserim
Moulmein
Ava
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Durbhunga
Sarun
Shahabad
Gya
Patna
Hazareebagh
Lohardugga
Chaibassa
Manbhoom
Singhbhoom
Sambalpur
Raipore
Sirguja
Bilaspore
Nagpore
Chanda
Sagar
Jubbulpore
Saugor
Nerbudda
Mandla
Seoni
Chhindwara
Betul
Hoshangabad

Beginning of Colonial Rule (1757)

- Started after the Battle of Plassey
- British East India Company took control
- Bengal became a source of revenue
- Focus on extraction, not development

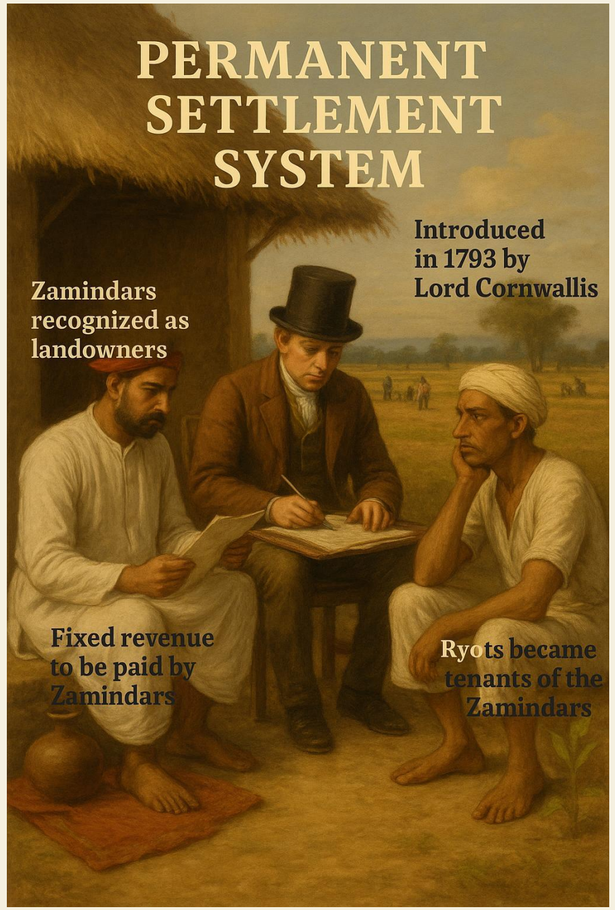
This battle marked the beginning of British political and economic dominance in Bengal under the British East India Company.

The Battle of Plassey in 1757 marked the beginning of British control in Bengal.
After defeating Nawab Siraj-ud-Daulah, the British East India Company took control over Bengal's administration and revenue system.
Bengal was one of the richest regions in South Asia, famous for textiles, agriculture, and trade.
But instead of developing Bengal, the British treated it as a source of revenue and raw materials.

Permanent Settlement (1793)

- Fixed land revenue system
- Zamindars collected taxes
- High pressure on peasants
- Land loss if unable to pay

The fixed land revenue system where zamindars were responsible for collecting taxes from peasants and paying them to the British government. Because the revenue demand was very high, zamindars increased rent on peasants.
If peasants could not pay, they often lost their land.



An Ai image representing permanent settlement

Agrarian Collapse

- Loss of land rights
- Increased debt
- Permanent rural poverty
- Weakening of village structure

Farmers lost traditional land rights and became dependent on landlords and moneylenders.
Many peasants had to borrow money just to survive, which created long-term debt.
As a result, rural poverty became permanent.

Result: Long-term peasant suffering

Indigo Revolt (1859–60)

- Forced indigo cultivation
- Reduced food production
- Exploitation and violence
- Organized peasant A

British planters forced farmers to grow indigo instead of food crops. And Indigo was profitable for the British, but it brought losses for peasants. So, Farmers were trapped through unfair contracts, violence, and threats. Because less land was used for food production, economic insecurity increased.

Deindustrialization

- British goods replaced local industries
- Textile sector declined
- Artisans lost jobs
- Growth of urban poverty

British industrial goods entered Indian markets at lower prices, making local products unable to compete. At the same time, colonial policies discouraged local industrial development. Bengal changed from a producer economy into a dependent market for British goods. This process is called deindustrialization.

Drain of Wealth

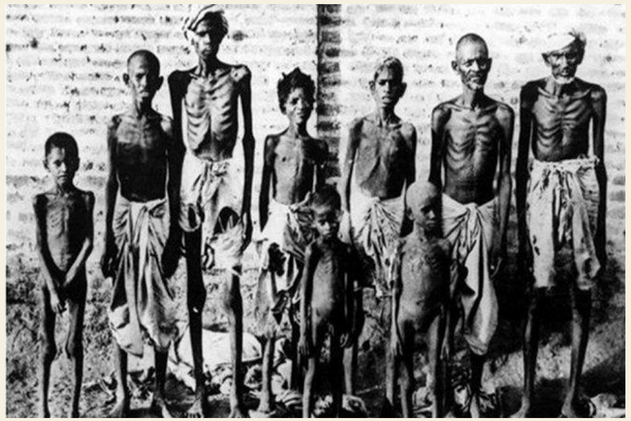
- Resources sent to Britain
- No reinvestment in Bengal
- Economy weakened
- Inequality increased

Britain became richer through colonial exploitation, while Bengal experienced poverty and weak economic growth. This created long-term structural inequality that continued even after colonial rule ended.

Mention: R. C. Dutt

R. C. Dutt described colonial rule as a system of “Drain of Wealth.” This means Bengal’s resources, taxes, and profits were continuously transferred to Britain without reinvestment.

Bengal Famine (1943)



- Millions died
- Food was available but inaccessible
- Wartime policies worsened crisis
- Administrative failure

The Bengal Famine of 1943 was one of the worst human disasters in Bengal’s history.
Millions of people died from starvation. This is called entitlement failure. The famine showed the complete collapse of governance and social protection.

Peak Social Collapse

- Extreme poverty spread across Bengal
- Mass unemployment increased
- Food security and relief systems failed
- Bengal Famine of 1943 marked the peak of collapse

Result: Fragile society

People waiting in long relief lines for food, reflecting the failure of distribution and governance during the crisis.

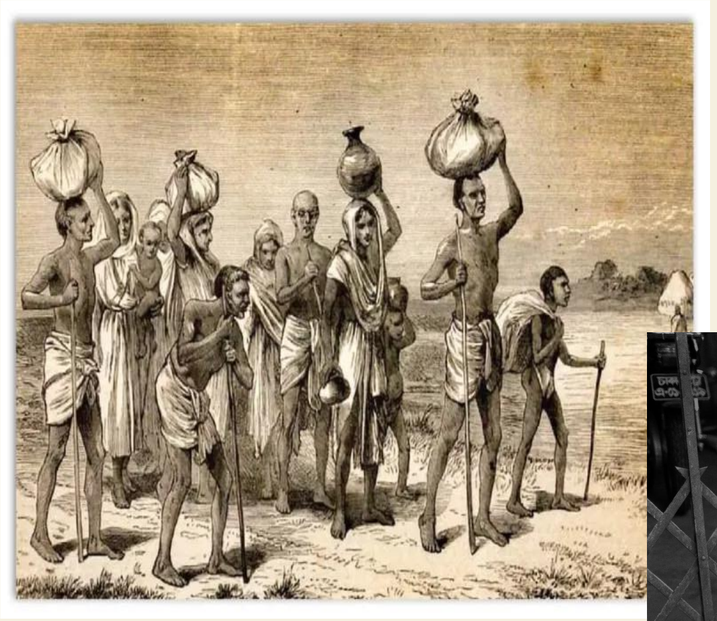
By the early 20th century, the combined effects of agrarian crisis, deindustrialization, and economic exploitation had reached their highest level.
Poverty became widespread in both villages and cities. Many people lost their land, jobs, and basic means of survival.
Food insecurity became severe, and social protection systems completely broke down.

Structural Impact of Colonial Policies

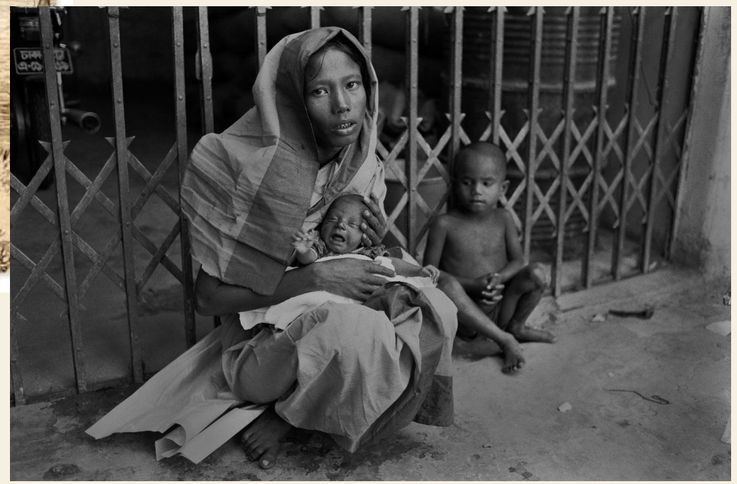
- Social collapse resulted from interconnected economic and institutional factors
- Agrarian collapse, industrial decline, and wealth extraction reinforced each other
- Created a cycle of long-term poverty and instability
- Colonial “modern” systems mainly served British interests
- Effects continued even after colonial rule ended
- Unequal land distribution, rural poverty, and weak institutions still exist

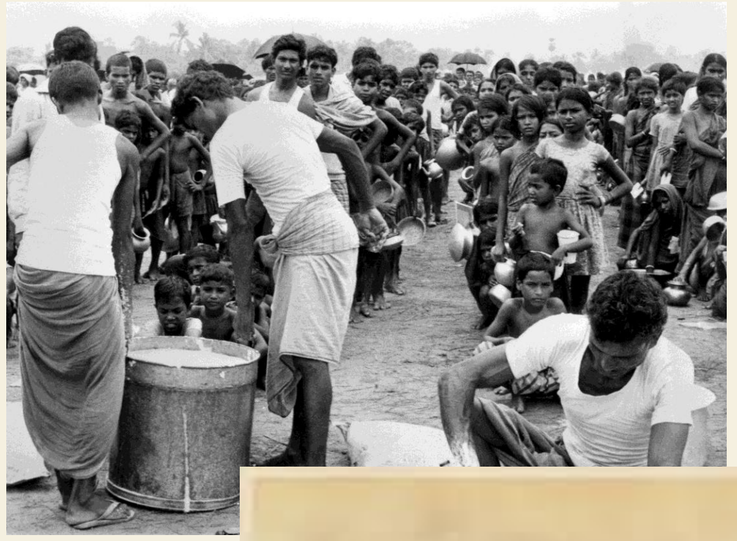
Unequal land ownership, rural poverty, weak institutions, and economic dependency remain important issues today. Colonial policies created structural inequality that shaped post-colonial development.

Some scenarios during collapse



Famine Victims





In the 1900s, Champaran's farmers were being forced by British planters to grow.

Conclusion

- Colonial policies reshaped Bengal permanently
- Agriculture, industry, and society were weakened
- Social collapse was structural, not accidental

The social collapse of Bengali society was the result of these long-term structural changes. Agrarian collapse, deindustrialization, famine, and wealth extraction were all connected. Their effects continue to influence Bangladesh today.
To understand present inequality and development challenges, it is necessary to understand colonial history.

Thank You